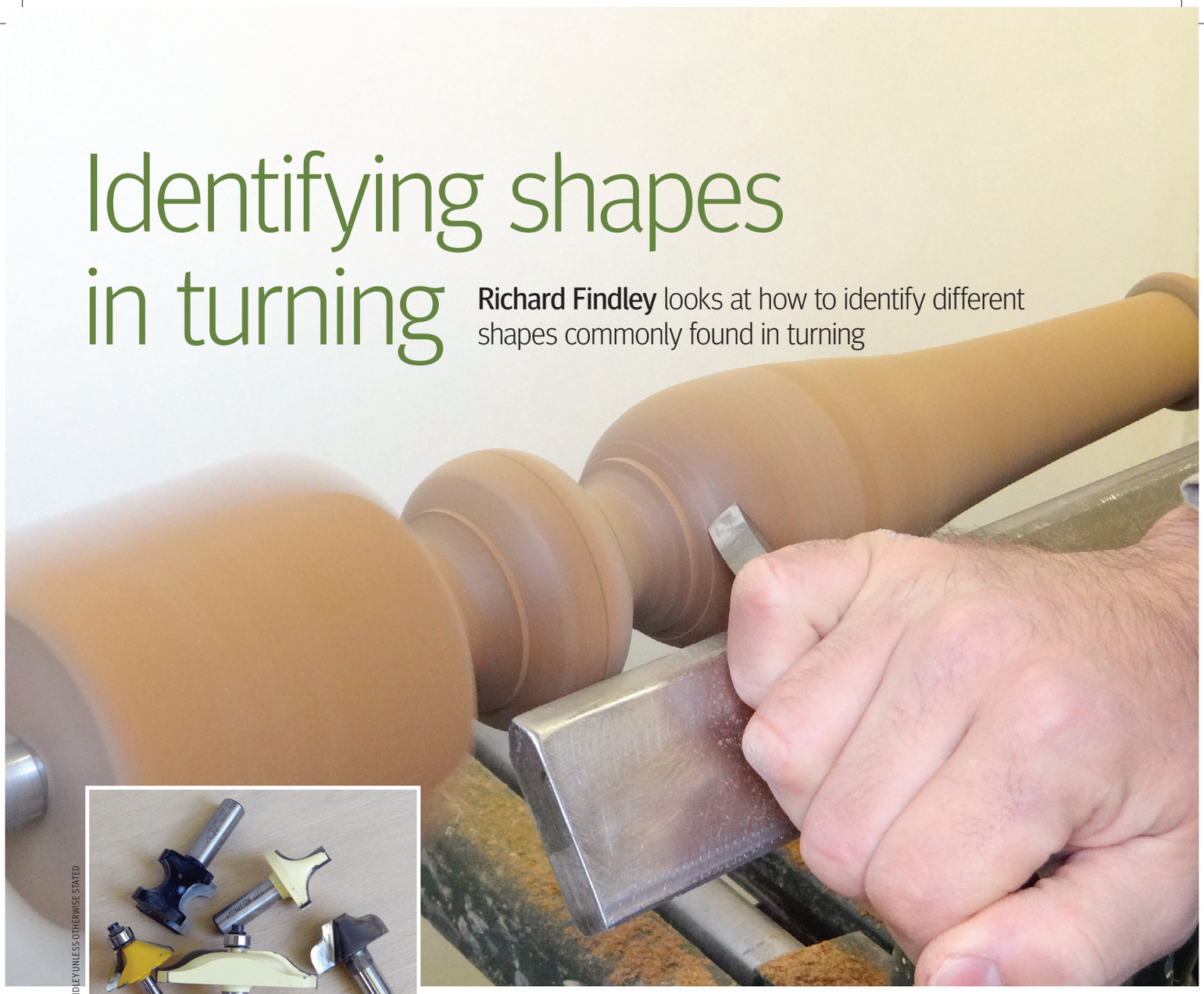
Identifying shapes in turning

Richard Findley looks at how to identify different shapes commonly found in turning



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Assorted router cutters to produce edge moulds. These shapes are closely related to many of the shapes used in turning

RICHARD FINDLEY

Richard is a registered UK professional woodturner living and working in Leicestershire. He discovered woodturning while working for his father as a joiner. He makes all kinds of work to commission, from replacement antique components, walking canes and stair spindles, to decorative bowls. It is the variety of work that he loves. He also offers demonstrations and a range of woodturning supplies.

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Over the past few series I have looked at the techniques of turning various different shapes into timber, whether that be spindle work or faceplate turning. To begin this new series I thought it might be interesting and useful to look at how to identify some of these shapes by name. It is commonly quoted that there are only three shapes in turning:

- Beads: or positive curved shapes
- Coves: or negative curved shapes
- Straight lines: positioned at any angle

This is correct, however these shapes can be stretched, squashed and combined to make new shapes. They are still based on the basic bead and cove, but have different names that help to distinguish them from each other. Here, I will try to show each of these shapes with their names and explain where they can be commonly found and used.

Many of the shapes are closely related to the traditional mouldings that can be seen in most houses in one form or another, whether on the skirting boards, dado rails, picture rails or simply decorating the edge of a shelf. They will vary in complexity from a simple bevelled edge, bullnose or round over, to ovolo or ogee mouldings. A look at a router cutter catalogue will show you cutters that will produce most of these shapes on the edges of timber.

The shapes used in faceplate work are directly linked to these mouldings, and as I described last month, the forms used in faceplate work are also used in spindle turning, although they are slightly manipulated to make them work in this way.

WHY DO I NEED TO KNOW THIS?

In short, I suppose you don't. That said, it is always good to expand your knowledge and a deeper understanding of a subject can only be a positive thing. It can also be useful to know the names of these shapes when designing your turnings or when watching a demonstrator, so if he describes what he's doing and throws in a technical name of a shape, you will know what he's talking about!

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